



Palazzo Ducale

An architectural masterpiece designed as a setting for the life of a cultured Renaissance court

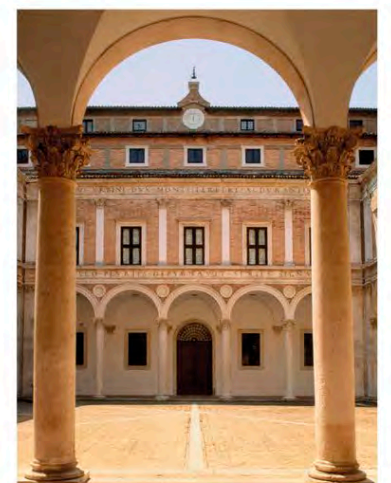
Dominating the walled town of Urbino in the Marche region of Italy, Palazzo Ducale (“Ducal Palace”) was created to satisfy the social and cultural ambitions of Federico da Montefeltro (1422–1482), a minor aristocrat who had won fame and fortune as a mercenary general. Duke Federico aspired to make his court a renowned center of humanist learning and civilized manners.

Courtly life

From 1465, Federico employed architect Luciano Laurana to rebuild and extend the existing castle at Urbino. Laurana created two slender towers, with a loggia (covered area) between them, providing fine

views over the surrounding hills. Inside the building, a monumental stairway led from an arcaded courtyard to the upper stories. Federico’s devotion to Classical learning was evident in a magnificent library, an exquisite personal study (the *studiolo*), and a “temple of the muses” dedicated to the deities of ancient Rome.

Succeeding Laurana after 1472, engineer Francesco di Giorgio Martini installed an innovative plumbing system that showed regular baths were a part of the Duke’s ideal of civilized living. The wit and elegance of the courtly life at Urbino were later celebrated by Baldassare Castiglione in his *Book of the Courtier* (1528). The palace now houses an outstanding collection of Renaissance art.



△ MAIN COURTYARD

The arcaded courtyard, with its Classical proportions, is among the oldest parts of the palace. Built in pale stone and brick, it is topped with an inscription that celebrates the glory of Federico.